A bizarre durbar assembled around the deposed Shah. The head of Shuja's household was Mullah Shakur Ishaqzai – 'a short, fat person', wrote Harlan, '[whose] rotundity . . . was adequately finished by the huge turban characteristic of his class, encased in voluminous outline by a profusion of long thick hair which fell upon his shoulders in heavy sable silvered curls'. The curls were there for a purpose: to hide the absence of his ears, which had been removed at Shuja's orders as a punishment for an earlier failure of courage on the field of battle. But the mullah was in good company, at least according to Harlan, who claimed that Shuja had developed the habit of removing pieces of his household's anatomy whenever they failed to perform: many of the ears, tongues, noses and genitals of Shuja's servants had been forfeited at different points, resulting in 'an earless assemblage of mutes and eunuchs in the ex-king's service'.

The unfortunate Chief Eunuch, an African Muslim named Khwajah Mika, had allegedly lost his manhood when a harem screen protecting Wa'fa Begum and the King's other wives had been blown down by a gust of wind, though 'the executioner was of a tender conscience', reported Harlan, and 'merely deprived Khwajah Mika of the lower part of the organ'. After this, the subsequent loss of his ears had been but a minor blow, and, unlike Mullah Shakur, the Chief Eunuch had 'shaved his head and now fearlessly displayed the mark of royal favour'.[39]

Visitors who spent time with Shuja continued to be impressed by his charm, manners and dignity. The pioneering Central Asian traveller Godfrey Vigne, for example, reported that Shuja was 'good natured . . . looking more like a gentleman who has lost an estate than a monarch who had lost his kingdom'.[40] Moreover, Shuja was also ahead of his time in establishing a school for his dependants: by 1836 there were approximately 3,000 school-age males enrolled.[41] The records of the Ludhiana Agency, which survive in their entirety in the Lahore Archives, do however seem to confirm Harlan's hints that he was in other ways not one of the more enlightened employers in the Punjab: his slave girls, for example, were frequently reported as running off, possibly to escape Shuja's punishments, but in some cases 'to seek the protection' of the handsome young officers of the British garrison in the town. This inevitably led to several diplomatic stand-offs between the Ludhiana barracks and the Afghan court-in-exile.[42]